Tabletop 2: A Trusted Connection

Student Investigation Packet | Third-party coordination, scoping, evidence planning, and containment tradeoffs

Fictional training exercise. All records are simplified and use one exercise day, HarborMart local time UTC-04:00. No real tools or external contacts are required. Do not open domains or attempt actions against real systems.

Your assignment

Northstar Inventory Support reports compromise of technician account ns-support-17, which can remotely access HarborMart. Determine potential exposure, evidence needs, and proportionate restrictions.

Information is intentionally incomplete. Missing fields are not proof of malicious activity. Request specific information from the moderator, explain the question it answers, and record what remains unknown. Additional information will arrive during the exercise. Some uncertainty is deliberately unresolved.

Authority and coordination

The incident lead coordinates response and may approve temporary restrictions on an individual account or workstation. IT administrators implement changes. Disrupting shared production services requires leadership and system-owner coordination. Legal/privacy coordinates external notification assessment; communications manages approved external messaging. External engagement follows designated relationship owners. These are fictional HarborMart exercise rules.

T2-A | Vendor notice

Northstar reports unauthorized use of ns-support-17 during 08:00-11:00. It cannot yet classify customer sessions as legitimate or unauthorized. Detailed vendor records are pending.

T2-B | Access and operations

The approved destination is HM-INV-01 via the vendor gateway. Expected work is diagnostics and approved configuration changes. No maintenance ticket exists for this morning. Replenishment processing begins at noon. HarborMart staff can operate inventory without vendor support; disabling vendor access does not itself stop the inventory application.

T2-C | Gateway records

ID / time	Destination	Activity by ns-support-17
C1 08:22	HM-INV-01	Session opened
C2 08:37	HM-INV-01	File transfer recorded; filename unavailable

ID / time	Destination	Activity by ns-support-17
C3 08:45	HM-INV-01	Session closed

T2-D | Server excerpt

ID / time	Observation
D1 08:25	Vendor support process started
D2 08:34	inventory_export.csv created in temporary directory
D3 08:44	Temporary file deleted

Team discussion

1. What access is established, and what is only suspected?

2. Does the packet prove the transferred file contents or data theft?

3. Which HarborMart evidence should be preserved and which vendor records requested?

4. Recommend a targeted restriction and explain its business impact.

5. Who should coordinate technical changes and vendor communication?

Team Decision Record

Team: _____ Recorder: _____

Investigative question

_____

_____

Supported observations: cite record IDs

_____

_____

Current explanation and one alternative

_____

_____

Missing information: request, purpose, and owner

_____

_____

Initial recommendation: action, rationale, priority, and approval

_____

_____

Update received: what changed?

_____

_____

Revised recommendation and stakeholder communications

_____

_____

Reassessment trigger / remaining uncertainty

_____

_____

Prepare a 60-second update: What we know; what we do not know; what we recommend; who needs to act; what happens next.